

iii. pulsing

i'm standing on the edge and i think you would be here too.
at home youre clinking forks on plates and gossiping in loud voices.
but im standing on the edge; and somewhere, i feel you with me.
but it was never you, was it? it was always me.
if that makes you hiccup,
itll be more of a reaction than you gave me.

i push my toes past the edge and i think: is this how you felt, too?
crying with your fingers knotted in your hair; did you pull?
if i could replace your fingers with mine, i would tug so slightly
your head tilts back and your mouth pops open, and i can perform rescue breaths.
but im not resuscitating you: im just whispering *love me love me love me love*
until they have to notice and pull me off of you: i hate you.

i wait, running my hands over the stubble on my legs; does it feel
like the hair i noticed you didnt cut. like the scars you never can,
like the body we can only sweat off. i wish i said yes to every question.

run away with me

yes

hold my hand

of course

do you starve

for you

give it to me

alright.

do you like someone

yeah

come closer

sure

can i

please.

without alleging we were anything; arent we, at least in
the nature of a teenage girl? to be a gaping hole; slick
with the call of danger. i stop your hand before you remind me firetrucks
dont stop at a red light. this concrete cliff ringing

in wanting. *sati* is the ritual burning of widows, sacrifice on your warden's pyre.
so i mutter a prayer to *durga ma* before kissing you sloppy, clinking teeth and all;
and i let go of your hand and i push you; and i yearn a little more when you dont resist.

they will think my womb is empty, and they will want to fill it.
yet they dont know that monthly, it fills with all the blood that collected
at the foot of that concrete building, staining taxpayer sidewalks.
(every action has an equal and opposite reaction; so i will wait until
i can taste the salt brining your lips. and all the historians will deny it,
but our kinfolk will hear us like whale calls: *i love you, i love you, i love you.*)